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'You got this!': A critical discourse analysis of toxic positivity as a discursive construct on Facebook

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ABSTRACT

An increasing number of Australian organisations and charities are making use of social media platforms to raise public awareness, gather funds, organise events, and educate and support individuals with invisible chronic conditions (ICCs). During the COVID-19 crisis, the social disconnectedness already experienced by individuals with ICCs led to a rapid rise in their use of social media, mainly for emotional purposes. Although more and more systemic functional linguistic studies of electronically mediated discourse are being carried out, few of them have focused on dialogical interaction and power relationships between organisations engaging with social media, and their followers. The article examines several types of discourse on two public Facebook pages advocating for endometriosis awareness. It adopts a discourse-analytical approach to show how the discursive construct of toxic positivity is enmeshed in power and ideology. Two corpora of posts and comments were extracted from the Endometriosis Australia and MyEndometroisisTeam Facebook pages and analysed combining Systemic Functional Linguistics, Pragma-dialectics, and critical theory. The study revealed that both dominant and other interlocutors on the social media platform often engage in discursive moves inspired by neoliberal 'positive thinking' ideology, resulting in a less inclusive SNS platform, which may be redressed by an increased use of affirmative discourse.

1. Introduction

Social network services (SNS) aim to connect individuals with invisible chronic conditions (ICCs) with other users sharing the same issues. Virtual communities, such as Facebook, Reddit, or Twitter provide their members with information on specific ICCs, while raising awareness, and allow for an alternate way of interacting with others, which may lead to social issues such as online hate speech, sexism, or cyberbullying (Wodak and Meyer, 2015). This paper focuses on the discursive construction of toxic positivity. Although the term first appeared in Halberstam's (2011) work on 'the queer art of failure', the concept had already been explored by psychologists. For example, Weinstein (1980) explored the phenomenon of unrealistic optimism, of which toxic or forced positivity may be considered a strong correlate. He discovered that individuals believed that they would never become the victim of any severe disease, wrongly assuming that only others experienced such suffering, due to their own fault, as, in their view, "success happens to good people and failure is just a consequence of a bad attitude rather than structural conditions" (Weinstein 1980, p. 3). Since individuals interacting with one another on SNS platforms inevitably compare themselves to their peers, the same illusion of invulnerability may arise, leading to unrealistic expectations of the future and others. This may lead to divergent viewpoints and conflicting perceptions of reality.

Individuals tend to make highly personal statements on Facebook pages. Due to the increased distance between followers, it can be tempting for other users to reply to these statements using cliché expressions which are challenging to refute and often contain illogical reasoning. In order to reveal how SNS users discursively construe toxic positivity, two public Facebook pages, Endometriosis Australia (EA) and MyEndometriosisTeam (MET), both representing organisations promoting endometriosis awareness, were selected, merely for illustrative purposes. While any SNS will show the construal of some degree of toxic positivity, virtual communities consisting of members with an ICC are particularly suitable places for investigating the construct and its discursive manifestations, as users make frequent statements on the platform expressing distress and the interlocutors' comments and replies may reveal tangible discrepancies in terms of individual representations of the reality of living with an ICC, as well as some degree of bias and power incongruencies.

Toxic or forced positive discourse (FPOSD) is discourse imbued with an overly exaggerated positive outlook on the world (Bosveld, 2021; Ehrenreich, 2010). Once individuals have self-appropriated this type of discourse, it may become internalised and its use considered acceptable within a certain milieu. Due to the larger distance between users, SNS often form the perfect breeding ground for forced positivity, decreasing any feelings of genuine compassion (Burke and Kraut, 2016). The

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two Facebook pages from which the data for this study were extracted were developed to raise awareness about endometriosis, an often debilitating chronic inflammatory condition associated with pelvic pain and infertility, for which no cure exists (Marlin et al., 2021). The first public Facebook page is Australian and linked to an organisation established in 2013, while the second one is American and associated with an online forum. As per 4 November 2021, both pages have more than 40,000 followers.

The study of discursive exchanges in virtual communities is a growing field of interest (Gardner and Alsop, 2016). Several functional linguists have explored affiliation in social media discourse, for example by adopting Zappavigna's theoretical framework (Inwood and Zappavigna, 2021; Zappavigna and Logi, 2021; Makki and Zappavigna, 2021; Newton, 2020). Others opted for a multimodal approach (O'Halloran, 2008), with corpus linguistics methods increasingly gaining in popularity (Bednarek, 2010; Ross and Logi, 2021). The present study adopts a discourse-analytical approach to investigate the influence of power and ideology on the different types of discourse, including FPOSD, that are being exchanged on two public Facebook pages raising awareness for endometriosis through a combination of Systemic Functional Linguistics (SFL), Pragma-dialectics, and critical theory. The study reveals that the discursive construct of toxic/forced positivity in the samples is embedded in power relations and underpinned by unrealistic optimism revoking the neoliberal ideology of 'being in control of one's body'. Examining toxic positive patterns and illogical reasoning in discourse may help SNS users avoid employing discourse that shows the same constructs or argumentation and aid online content moderation.

2. Literature review

Hodge (2017) argues that both SFL and CDS take Halliday's social semiotic theory as their point of departure for discourse analysis. Language is connected with its immediate and wider context through register, consisting of field, tenor, and mode, creating a 'semantic configuration' (Halliday, 2002). All individuals use three different functions of language to build meaning, referred to by Halliday and Matthiessen (2014) as 'metafunctions'. They use these functions simultaneously to express their representations of the world (ideational/experiential) and to interact with others (interpersonal), with the third function bringing the two together as information (textual). It can be said that Halliday's (1994) transitivity system "construes the world of experience into a manageable set of PROCESS TYPES" (p. 106). Subsequently, a transitivity analysis focuses on activities included in the verbal processes in the discourse, as well as any Participants involved in the processes and the circumstances in which they take place (Halliday and Matthiessen, 2014). Material processes construe "a quantum of change in the flow of events as taking place through some input of energy" (Halliday and Matthiessen, 2014, p. 179), as a subject performs an action onto someone or something. Examples from the corpus, with reference to FPOSD, include transitive (e.g. 'You got this!') and intransitive processes (e.g. 'March into yellow!'). Relational processes, on the other hand do not involve any input of energy as they unfold. They can be identifying (e.g. 'Endometriosis is the silent disease') or attributive (e.g. 'Stay strong!'). Butt et al. [quoted in Haig (2009)] refer to the intensive identifying relational process as the 'power house of semiosis'. Comprising a Token (Identified) and a Value (Identifier), it seems to be highly common in FPOSD. Halliday and Matthiessen (2014) argue that, in this type of clause, "the two halves refer to the same thing" (p. 279):

(1) EndoWarriors (Tk/Id) **are** the most courageous people we know (V/Idf).

Mental processes can be subdivided into three classes: cognition (e.g. 'Know that better days are coming'), perception (e.g. 'I hear you'), desideration (e.g. 'Wishing you baby dust'), or emotion (e.g. 'I love it!'). The three remaining processes are behavioural ('Just breathe through it'), verbal ('Express yourself'), and existential ('There is always tomorrow').

Every single interaction between the two pages and their users or amongst users themselves involves power. A grammatical analysis of the Participants' transitivity choices may reveal how they perceive themselves and others in terms of agency, as Participants who carry out the actions tend to be represented as more powerful, while those undergoing them are often being represented as less powerful. It may further show how the pages' followers characterise and identify important entities, such as endometriosis as a disease, individuals with the condition, or more abstract entities such as pain, through the use of relational processes. More specifically, an investigation of intensive identifying relational processes may provide insight into which values are employed by the virtual community members to identify Tokens (Thompson, 2013). This is of particular relevance when it comes to FPOSD, which appears to be based on common homogeneous values and encourages a type of assimilasionist equality.

The Participants' interactions within the virtual space are motivated by various ideological representations, which are based on both individual and shared beliefs and values. Lukin (2018) explains that ideological positioning provides social actors with "principles for the recognition of, and legitimate participation in, culturally recognised forms of interaction" (p. 72). These principles are by no means homogeneous in nature, as Hasan (2009a, 2009b) clearly showed in her study of semantic variation.

The totality of posts, comments, and replies on the pages further constitutes a 'communicative act complex' aiming to elicit a response, turning the exchange into a dialogue and users into protagonists (P) and antagonists (A) (van Eemeren et al., 2014). The resulting complex speech act has both illocutionary and perlocutionary effects, which are highly pertinent in the context of social media, since users are constantly asked to interpret posts or comments and to either accept or dismiss their impetus for action. Pragma-dialectics takes the functional analysis one step further by reconstructing and evaluating the interactants' arguments in terms of reasonableness and effectiveness (van Eemeren, Garssen and Meuffels, 2009). According to Pragma-dialectics, any dissensions between interlocutors may be resolved through a critical discussion, as strategic manoeuvring occurs (van Eemeren, 2010). The validity of the interactants' argumentation may be critically evaluated by reviewing the acceptability of their standpoints and scrutinising their arguments for any illogical reasoning or fallacies (van Eemeren and Grootendorst, 2004). A pragma-dialectical analysis does not focus on intent, but on arguments as rhetorical artifacts which have various pragmatic effects. As van Eemeren et al. (2013) explain:

Whereas the motives people may have for holding a position might be different from the grounds they offer and accept in its defence, what they can be held committed to is not so much their actual position, but the position they have expressed in the discourse, whether directly or indirectly (p. 276).

This standpoint allows for argumentation theory to be used as an add-on analytical tool to SFL. While the latter accounts for meaning-making between Participants within a specific context of situation, Pragma-dialectics logically analyses the interlocutors' externalised reasoning in various modes of argumentation established through dialogue, with the ultimate aim of resolving any differences of opinion (Table 1).

It is often hoped that social media will unify its users and that norms for expected behaviour can be established at a global rather than local level. Seen the fact that the audience of a Facebook page tends to be culturally and socially heterogeneous, however, this assumption may create unexpected issues and result in sociopragmatic failure, especially in the context of unequal power equations (Foucault, 1980). Discourse is usually seen as a tool employed by individuals to share knowledge or to interact with others. Foucault (1978) moves beyond this narrow view by asserting that discourse is "both an instrument and an effect of power" (p. 101). Any FPOSD circulating on SNS platforms forces its users

Table 1
Overview of research method for the study.

	SFL	Pragma-dialectics	Critical theory
Focus	Functional meanings	Rhetorical meanings	Power structures and ideological motivators
Goals	Representations of reality/Agency	Logical fallacies and pragmatic effects	Impact of power and ideology
Analytical tools	Transitivity analysis	Reconstruction and evaluation of argumentation	Critical evaluation based on the literature
Parameters of discursive interaction	Context of situation	Context-sensitive	Socio-cultural context

Table 2
Types of discourse used on the EA and MET FB pages.

Dominant discourse	EA posts	MET posts	Participant discourse	EA comments and replies	MET comments and replies
Forced positive discourse	30%*	20%	Forced positive discourse	23%	1%
Affirmative discourse	5%	41%	Affirmative discourse	17%	4%
Other discourse	65%	39%	Other discourse	60%	95%

* Percentages are approximate.

into adhering to the norms it represents, as such becoming a discursive strategy in itself.

All posts on the two pages were interpreted as dominant discourse (DD), as they constitute discourse employed by the page to construe a 'system of truth' (Foucault, 1980), primarily by establishing that 'x is y' through the use of intensive identifying relational processes (Table 2):

(2) Owning our story and loving ourselves (x) **is** the bravest thing that we'll ever do (y).

As Foucault (1980) observes, "truth is a thing of the world" (p. 131). When mundane truths are produced by entities in power, this may result in trite formulae concealing everyday reality.

Any comments and replies were grouped together as participant discourse (PD).

Several comments and replies appeared to contain FPOSD on EA (23%) and MET (1%), since they displayed the same characteristics of exaggeratedly positive language:

(3) EA: I have two children conceived naturally. *Believe in your own body!*

MET: *You've got this!*

The same repetitive pattern of facile inspirational expressions was found in some of the posts on EA (30%) and MET (20%):

(4) EA: Sometimes we need a reminder to acknowledge our achievements and be kind to ourselves.

MET: Reminder: you totally got this!

Internalised FPOSD was encountered as well, as the result of an individual's self-appropriation of ubiquitous FPOSD use encountered on SNSs:

(5) EA: I am 1 in 9. My heart goes out to all Endo Warriors!

Affirmative discourse (AD), characterised by a different type of 'x is y' construct, attributing a specific quality to an entity through the use of an intensive attributive relational process, was seen in responses to various statements of distress by EA (5%) and MET (41%):

(6) MET: My friends are calling me a liar and a monster.
Reply: *We are sorry to hear that people close to you don't understand life with endometriosis.*

It was also found in followers' replies to other users' comments on EA (17%) and MET (4%):

(7) EA: I was told an 18-month wait for surgery and now it will be even longer. I'm in so much pain.
Reply: *It's awful.* I wish you the best in managing your symptoms for now.

The remainder of the DD and PD was labelled 'other' (or neutral) discourse.[1]

3. Research method

A total of 304 posts (1274 clauses) and 4780 comments and replies on the EA page, added between 1 January and 31 December 2020, were retrieved via API interrogation of the page through the use of Facepager (Keyling and Jünger, 2013). Then, an additional 400 posts (741 clauses), published between 1 March 2020 and 14 November 2021, including comments and replies, were collected from the MET page. Since both pages are public, the data were knowingly made available by individuals. Nevertheless, they were still anonymised by removing user ids or any other elements which could lead to the users' identification. The author was never in contact with any of the pages' followers regarding the research project.

The EA posts, comments and replies were downloaded from Facepager and the data organised in separate csv files according to the type of discourse, as mentioned earlier. In a similar fashion, the MET data were sorted based on the types of discourse they contained. This initial selection should be seen as the first step in the analysis. It needs to be noted that a certain amount of PD remained inaccessible, which became evident from the following message in the comments section on the EA page: "Most relevant is selected, so some comments may have been filtered out" (Endometriosis Australia, n.d.).

The text of the posts was then prepared for analysis: any hashtags, emoticons, links to websites and direct quotes were removed to obtain the raw discourse uttered by the administrator(s) of the page, and the same thing was done for the discourse contained in the followers' comments and replies. The decision was made to retain any quotes in images posted by the pages. Subsequently, the obtained data were analysed using the UAM corpus tool (O'Donnell, 2008), according to Halliday's SFL theory, by labelling all verbal processes in the main clauses. As Halliday (1994) posits, the system of transitivity allows language users to "impose order on the endless variation and flow of events" through their use of various process types (p. 106). The followers' transitivity choices were studied with regard to the impact of power and ideology on the discourses, with a specific focus on FPOSD. Then, some of the users' arguments were reconstructed and critically evaluated by examining them for logical fallacies (van Eemeren and Grootendorst, 2004). Finally, an attempt was made at uncovering possible ideological motivations behind the FPOSD used on the SNSs.

[1] It is important to note that all interactants use a blend of different types of discourse on the SNS.

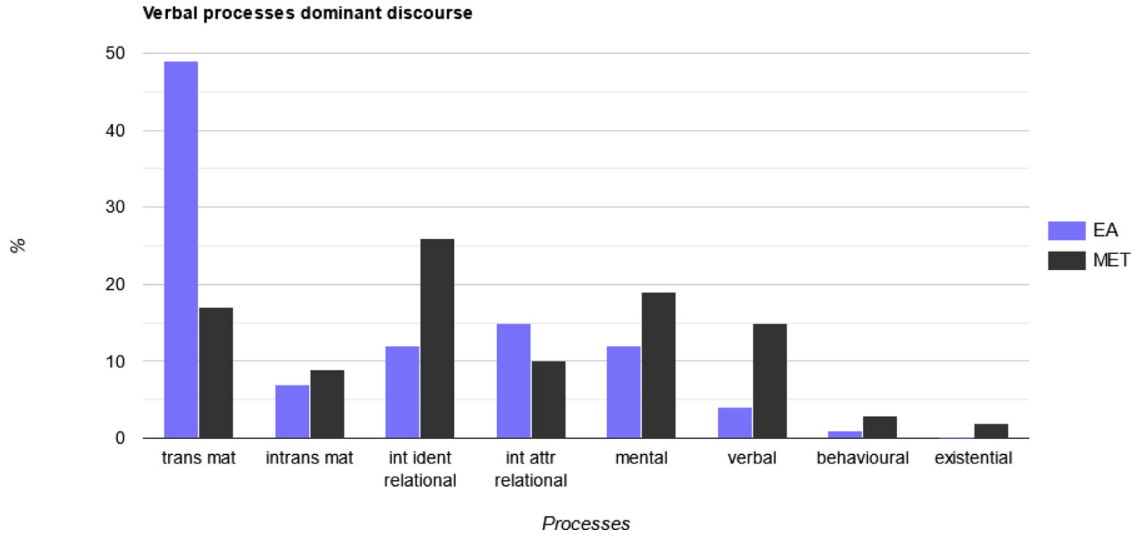


Fig. 1. Process types in DD.

Table 3
Actors in DD EA.

Actors	Frequency
Page followers (implied)	62%
Endometriosis Australia	17%
Journalists/blog writers	4%
Medical professionals	3%
Endo champions/warriors	2%
Other (below 2%)	12%

4. Results

4.1. Dominant discourse

From their selection of verbal processes, it becomes clear that the EA page mainly uses material processes when uttering DD (Fig. 1). The large majority of these are transitive (49%), with followers being represented by the organisation as most frequent Actors (62%) (Table 3). However, this large number of occurrences does not correlate with the individuals' agency, since they are mostly implied Actors in commands. amongst the predominantly inanimate Goals acted upon by the Participants are website links, forms, money, fundraisers, online stores, or their own bodies and minds. The only animate entities under the control of individuals with endometriosis are their friends. When it comes to having endometriosis, followers are represented as Actors although having a disease is more of a state, rather than an action. Medical professionals (3%) are construed as Agents acting upon the condition or individuals with endometriosis using powerful actions (Table 3):

(8) X was diagnosed with endometriosis **by her gyno**.
(9) Endometriosis had never been investigated or explored **by any doctors** in terms of a diagnosis.

Individuals with endometriosis are further mentioned twice as Actors, as subjects who may withdraw their participation from a research project, and as patients seeking surgery.

Goals acted upon by both the page and individuals with endometriosis include endometriosis, courage, the workplace and the conversation on periods:

(10) Let's end **endo**!
(11) Let's start **the conversation on periods**.

The EA page further construes itself as an important Actor (17%) affecting various animate and inanimate Goals (Table 3). A large number of its activities occur in the context of research, such as collaborating with universities and research centres, processing applications for research funding, or recruiting research participants, while other actions focus on raising funds for the organisation, such as partnering with small businesses, or organising and promoting fundraising events. Typical FB page activities such as recommending news articles, blogs, or sharing links to the website or podcasts are seen as well. EA is further engaged in the endorsement of government decisions (e.g. the postponement of all elective surgery) or fundraising events.

In contrast, DD used by the MET page appears to favour relational processes (36%), in particular processes of the intensive identifying type (26%) (Fig. 1), expressed from a position of power through defining x as y:

(12) It(x/endometriosis)**'s** a day-by-day battle (y).

MET represents endometriosis as a powerful adversary that needs to be defeated, turning followers into warriors. Since posts on this page include less direct commands, the percentage of material processes is far lower than that on the EA page (25%) (Fig. 1).

4.2. Forced positive dominant discourse

Whenever the EA page uses FPOSD, it tends to mainly opt for relational processes (39%), especially those of the identifying type (23%) (Fig. 2). This type of process involves Token and Value as its Participants, both of which are nominal groups:

(13) Walking (Token) **is** medicine (Val).
(14) You (Token) **are** an Endo Warrior (Val).

One entity ('walking'/'you') is being identified as another entity ('medicine'/ 'an Endo Warrior') here, as the page construes a socio-symbolic relationship between the two. One follower replies to the proposition using internalised FPOSD:

(15) My daily walks with my fur baby (Token) **are** my medicine (Val).

Any FPOSD employed by the MET page follows the same linguistic pattern, favouring relational processes (50%) of the intensive identifying mode (29%), defining the best example of someone's strength and the best gift for a friend in pain:

(16) Pretending to be happy when you are in pain **is** the best example of how strong you are as a person.
(17) Your presence **is** the best gift you can give a friend who's in pain.

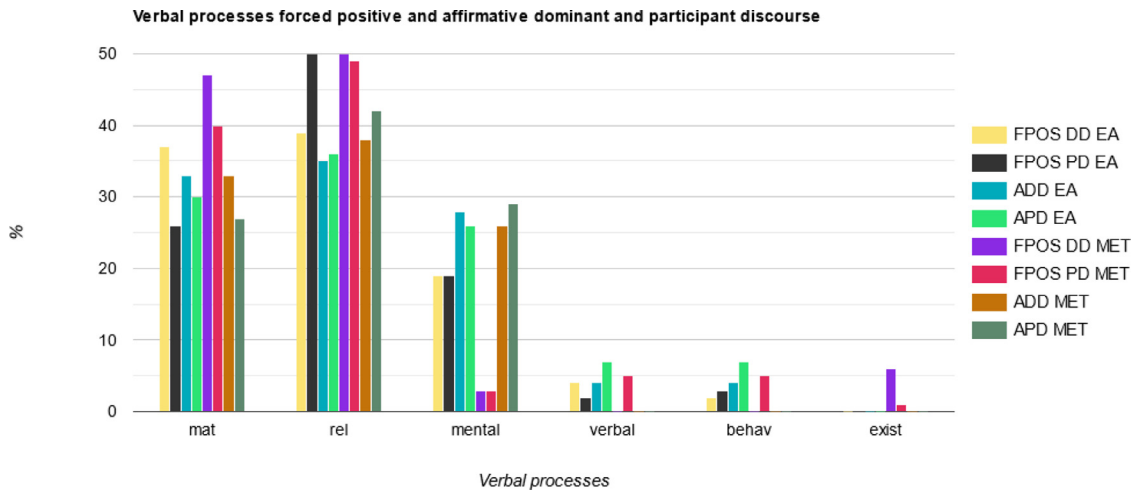


Fig. 2. Process types in FPOSD and AD.

Table 4
Actors in FPOS DD and PD.

Actors in FPOS DD on EA	Frequency	Actors in FPOS PD on EA	Frequency	Actors in FPOSD DD on MET	Frequency	Actors in FPOS PD on MET	Frequency
(Implied) you	40%	(Implied) you	35%	Inclusive 'we'	44%	(Implied) you	46%
Abstract entities	28%	I	27%	(Implied) you	25%	Inclusive 'we'	28%
Inclusive 'we'	12%	Abstract entities	16%	I	13%	Abstract entities	14%
Endometriosis	8%	Endometriosis	12%	Abstract entities	6%	I	11%
The EA page	8%	Individuals with endometriosis	4%	Nobody	6%	Endometriosis	1%
Individuals with endometriosis	4%	Both individuals giving and receiving replies	4%	People	6%		
		Hysterectomy	2%				

*Percentages are approximate.

The EA page further uses transitive material processes (33%) in FPOS DD, especially to express commands (Fig. 2). Individuals with endometriosis remain relegated to the position of implied Actors (40%) (Table 4):

(18) **Go** check it out and send some love!
(19) **Tag** your tribe!

Abstract entities such as strength, courage, or suffering function as Actors (28%) as well, which is highly characteristic of FPOSD (Table 4). In the example below, illness is represented as a powerful entity that needs to be overcome by its object:

(20) **Your illness** does not define you.

EA construes itself and its followers as important Actors (12%) through the use of first-person inclusive constructions (Table 4), attempting to include followers in various actions that are out of their control:

(21) Let**'s** end endo!
(22) Together, **we** can end endo!

As for the MET page, the most important Actors in its FPOSD are, again, the page and its followers, referred to using inclusive 'we' (44%):

(23) **We** go together like peas in a pod.

Implied 'you' in commands are common as well (25%):

(24) **Share** your go-to 'clap back' to the comments below.

MET also represents individuals with endometriosis as Actors using the first-person pronoun singular (13%):

(25) **I** am doing this for me!

Similar to EA, the page's FPOS DD further attributes agency to abstract entities (6%):

(26) Sometimes **a little love** goes a long way.

4.3. Forced positive participant discourse

The SNS platforms' followers constitute a highly heterogeneous group of individuals, with or without endometriosis, who all interact with the pages and other users. Any FPOSD uttered by the pages' users shows highly similar grammatical patterns. Relational processes (50%), especially those of the intensive identifying type (35%), are also favoured by EA followers (Fig. 2):

(27) You **are** a fierce lioness of a woman.
(28) We **are** endo warriors; we can do anything.

EA followers are using internalised FPOSD here, labelling another follower as a 'lioness', which is a symbol of power, and themselves as 'endo warriors' who are able to control their own situation, which is, again, a type of ideological representation.

MET followers' FPOSD also primarily employs relational processes (49%), especially of the intensive identifying type (29%), although more data are required to draw any permanent conclusions, as both pages only display comments which they deem relevant:

(29) It (supplement) **is** the only way I can function with the same condition.

Table 5
Common fallacies in FPOSD (Van Eemeren et al., 2020).

Fallacious moves	Argument scheme
Fallacies of relevance	*Symptomatic argumentation*
Thought-terminating cliché	P asserts X. X sounds appealing. Therefore, X is true.
Position-to-know argument	X is true (Y). X is uttered by A. Being uttered by A is (not) an indication of Y.
Ad hominem	P argues X. P's behaviour is not acceptable. X is not a good argument.
Ad misericordiam	P argues X. A deserves pity due to Y. Y is irrelevant to X.
Ad crumenam	X is doing Y. Therefore, X is the right thing to do.
Ad passiones	P argues X. A utters emotion-filled Y. Y is irrelevant to X.
Ad consequentiam	X is true. Therefore, X will lead to Y.
Causal fallacies	*Causal argumentation*
Anecdotal evidence	X occurred before Y. Therefore, X caused Y.
Non sequitur	P claims X. P presents evidence for X. Therefore, claim Y is true.
Fallacy of relative privation	Situation X is presented. Situation Y is presented as a worse case. Therefore, situation X is good.
Loaded question	P asks X. A has to accept Y before answering X.

The followers' second most preferred process in FPOSD is material on EA (26%) and MET (40%), instructing other individuals with endometriosis on what to do, or how to behave:

(30) EA: **Find** a new GP who does support you.
(31) EA: **Hang** in there!
(32) MET: **Have** faith!

Subsequently, individuals with endometriosis are being represented as (implied) Actors on EA (35%) and MET (46%), and ordered to get into action:

(33) EA: **You**'ve got this!
(34) EA: X, **you** smash life!
(35) MET: Don't give up hope!
(36) MET: Hang in there, X!

The same entities are being represented as important Actors in first-person pronoun structures by followers of EA (27%) and MET ('we' 28% and 'I' 11%), as part of internalised FPOSD emphasising their strength:

(37) EA: **I** am the strongest person I know.
(38) MET: **We** are the strong ones!

Finally, various abstract entities are construed by EA (16%) and MET followers (14%) as important Actors as well, especially the condition itself (EA: 12%, MET: 1%), which is seen as a potent adversary:

(39) EA: **This disease** will never beat me!
(40) EA: **Endo** is not going to define me!
(41) MET: **This disease** will never stop me from doing the things I want.

The next section looks into the opposite of FPOSD: AD.

4.4. Affirmative dominant and participant discourse

Any AD employed by the pages shows the same linguistic patterns, strongly favouring relational processes (EA: 35%, MET: 38%). However, unlike in FPOSD, the intensive attributive type is favoured (EA: 31%, MET: 30%), attributing a quality (Value) to a person or other entity (Carrier):

(42) EA: We (Ca) **are** so sorry (Val), X.
(43) MET: That(Ca)**'s** awful (Val).

EA attributes the positive quality of 'sorry' to itself in example 43 and amplifies its intensity by adding 'so', whereas MET ascribes a negative attribute to 'that' (being in pain).

When replying to other followers' statements of distress, EA (34%) and MET (36%) followers predominantly use the same type of process to attribute various qualities to themselves, other users, and their situation, expressing empathy:

(44) EA: I **am** totally horrified to hear this.
(45) EA: **I'm** sorry you're going through this too.
(46) MET: You **are** not alone.
(47) MET: That**'s** so true.

5. Argument reconstruction and evaluation

Any FPOSD employed by EA, MET and their followers exerts various pragmatic effects on social actors involved in discussion threads on the FB pages. It is not always reasonable either and shows various fallacies of relevance and causal fallacies (Table 5). To assess the effectiveness of the interlocutors' argumentation, several critical questions may be asked, based on the argument schemes which are being instantiated. One common FPOS fallacious move that may occur in the interactants' FPOSD is a 'thought-terminating cliché' fallacy: a refusal to accept the burden of proof by making a claim without providing any evidence, discouraging any further exchange of ideas (MET):

(48) T1: I'm looking for a coffin dress. I'm so sad I can't have children.
T2: *Don't give up hope,* you can still get prego.

CQ1: Does the fact that proposition Y, uttered by antagonist A sounds appealing make it relevant to protagonist P's statement of distress X?

A follower may also posit that a perfect solution exists to treat T1's issue, which is an argument from a position to know (EA):

(49) T1: I'm waiting for a hysterectomy because I feel I've tried everything else.
T2: *A hysterectomy does not cure endo. You need excision surgery with an endo specialist.*

CQ1: Is it true that a hysterectomy is not a good treatment option?
CQ2: Is A in a position to know that a hysterectomy is not a good treatment option for P?
Another frequent fallacy is the 'ad hominem' argument (EA):

(50) T1: I wish I could feel proud.
T2: There's a great part in it [book] about how *your "disabilities" can actually be your superpower if you look at them from a different perspective.*

T2 questions the acceptability of T1's proposition, challenging them to defend their standpoint, which forms a direct attack on T1's person.
CQ1: Does P have bad character for a correct perspective of the situation?
A highly common fallacy in FPOSD is the 'appeal to pity' (MET):

(51) T1: I had nausea and diarrhoea on a daily basis due to endo. It sucks, this evil disease.
T2: *I have been suffering with endo for 24 years and had 28 operations. I've never let it stop me from doing the things I want.*

T2 appeals to T1's feelings by pointing out the reasons why T1 should care more about their situation than about their own, which is highly reductionist.

CQ1: Is A's emotional proposition Y relevant to P's situation?

When replying to comments, followers may provide anecdotal evidence, which cannot be verified, committing an 'anecdotal evidence' fallacy (MET):

(52) T1: I've been having belly button pain with cramping, hip and lower back pain while feeling nauseous.
T2: *Fruit!!! Huge plates of fruit daily have been the only thing that's helped my nausea!*

CQ1: Does the fact that A's nausea stopped after eating fruit mean that eating fruit resolved the issue of P's nausea?

Another common move during strategic manoeuvring is the 'argumentum ad consequentiam' (MET):

(53) T1: I still haven't found a way to manage the bloating!
T2: *A plate full of leafy greens, proteins and good fat helps a lot,* ***because*** *it makes the intestines work properly reducing the bloating.*

If A's proposition X ('leafy greens, proteins and good fat make the intestines work properly reducing the bloating') is true, then Y ('helps a lot') will occur, making X true.

CQ1: Is A's proposition true?

FPOSD often contains *non sequitur* arguments. In the example below, taken from the MET page, the fallacious move is signalled by 'so':

(54) T1: I had to end a few friendships this year because they were calling me a liar and monster.
T2: *I hate explaining it (endometriosis),* ***so*** *I don't bother talking to people anymore*.

CQ1: Is the fact that A hates to explain their condition relevant to their conclusion?

Another fallacious move occurs when A's reply reduces P's proposition by mentioning something worse, known as a fallacy of relative privation (EA):

(55) T1: Mine has been deferred. I waited for nearly 6 months for this surgery and now I don't know when it's going to happen.
T2: *Six months isn't a bad wait, truthfully. I had to wait longer*.

CQ1: Is P's situation good?

The organisation often recruits Endo Ambassadors to gather funds and raise awareness about endometriosis. When their fame is used to influence the page's followers, however, the result may be an appeal to wealth fallacy (EA):

(56) T1: X *also covers the strategies that help her manage her endometriosis and how she works to cultivate self-love and a positive body image.*
T2: Unfortunately right now, help is not out there. Not in regards to verbal help but physical help.

T1: *She is a real Endo Warrior!*

CQ1: Can someone's behaviour be seen as correct and worth repeating based on the fact that they are a celebrity?

Some of the text in the posts reads like an advertisement, appealing to the users' emotions (MET post):

(57) T1: *We go together like peas in a pod.*

CQ1: Is there any evidence for P's emotional proposition X?

Sometimes followers ask questions, which do not necessarily contain FPOSD. In some contexts, however, they may constitute a loaded question fallacy (EA):

(58) T1: I was told it was likely I have adenomyosis from an ultrasound, so it was recommended I have a hysterectomy.
T2: *Have you seen an endo specialist?*

T2 is asking T1 a loaded question here, to which T2 can only respond with 'yes' or 'no'.

CQ1: Does P have to accept Y?

Even though it may appear as if the interlocutors purposely employ FPOSD, it needs to be underlined that most of their utterances do not carry any deliberate intent and that the illocutionary effects of their bias are largely inadvertent though nonetheless potentially harmful, as revealed by the critical questions.

6. Ideological motivations

A critical evaluation of how organisations and individuals construe their own reality and argumentation surrounding ICCs may provide important insights into their online behaviour, leading to more profound reflection on possible pragmatic effects of the discourse they employ. FPOSD may be linked to dominant power structures inspiring digital representations of what it means to have an ICC. As the transitivity analysis has shown, the EA page primarily uses material verbal processes in its DD to construe itself as a potent Actor acting upon important entities, such as fundraisers, research opportunities, resources, or the website, whereas individuals with endometriosis are construed as less powerful entities that simply follow what the page instructs them to do, such as participate in fundraisers and research, purchase things online, listen to podcasts, and manage their bodies. Conversely, the MET page predominantly opts for relational processes of the intensive identifying type in their DD, probably due to the high amount of FPOSD in its posts, defining various entities and, as such, significant shared values, such as actively battling endometriosis, being strong, staying in control, and pretending to be happy.

Whenever EA uses FPOSD, it mostly selects intensive identifying relational processes to make powerful statements through the use of 'x is y' constructs, leaving followers with little or no ' strategic manoeuvring' space. Abstract entities such as amazing things or courage are attributed power as well. EA's objective is for patients "to be the CEOs of their own healthcare" (Endometriosis Australia, n.d.), which is reflected in the page's frequent labelling of patients as 'endo warriors'.

Organisations and medical professionals are increasingly making use of social media to enable individuals' self-management of their ICCs (Laliberté et al., 2016), which can have multiple advantages for both parties. It allows individuals to easily access reliable medical information for free, and provides doctors or specialists with a way of communicating with their patients. Through the use of multimedia such as podcasts, videos, interviews, and the like, individuals with ICCs are provided with a large number of tools to self-manage their disease. SNS are also fast becoming a useful means of recruiting patients and research subjects.

However, in neoliberalism, the "homo oeconomicus" is not a partner of exchange, as in the classical definition, but "an entrepreneur, an entrepreneur of himself" (Foucault 1978, p. 226). He is "someone who pursues his own interest, and whose interest is such that it converges spontaneously with the interest of others" (Foucault et al., 2008, p. 270), which echoes Smith's (1975) view that an individual is always seeking their own advantage and not necessarily that of society. Neoliberalism may be defined as

> a theory of political economic practice that proposes that human well-being can best be advanced by liberating individual entrepreneurial freedoms and skills within an institutional framework characterized by strong private property rights, free markets, and free trade (Harvey, 2005, p. 3).

The COVID-19 crisis turned the healthcare sector into an industry and, as the result of artificial intelligence (AI), Big Data, climate

change and the virus itself, transformed homo oeconomicus into "homo praeventicus" (Puaschunder 2020, p. 2). It is often argued that a preventive lifestyle is crucial in avoiding any further crises in the future, which recalls Facebook's novel Preventive Health tool that connects "people to health resources and checkup recommendations from leading health organisations" (Facebook, n. d.). SNS platforms, such as the public Facebook pages under investigation, are already playing a significant role in preventive healthcare by educating followers on topics such as diet, exercise, and self-management of their ICCs.

Unfortunately, the FPOSD employed on EA and MET seems to promote certain representations of the reality of living with endometriosis ('you are what you choose to become') and individuals with the ICC ('perseverance, bravery, strength and courage are the markings of an Endo Warrior') which may ignore any structural conditions contributing to the followers' individual situation and which may not correspond with the followers' representations of what it means to have endometriosis. Similarly, some of the EA and MET users appear to utter the same type of FPOSD, characterised by intensive identifying relational processes, to make highly symbolic yet shallow statements in response to other followers' statements of distress, such as 'courage is power', or 'tomorrow is another day'. Self-identifying as 'endo warriors', the followers seem to perceive endometriosis as a powerful adversary that can be managed and controlled with the correct mindset. Regrettably, their positive thinking may create the false assumption that a positive attitude is the only preferred mode of thought. This type of unrealistic or even cruel optimism, as Berlant (2011) defines it, is highly common on SNS, where Foucaultian discursive formations containing both images and text tend to flourish and support regimes of truth, determining what is acceptable and unacceptable in user discourse (Foucault, 2013). As the pragma-dialectical analysis demonstrates, some of the followers' discursive moves when uttering FPOSD are fallacious, since their argumentation may be deemed unreasonable and ineffective, based on logic.

Some scholars hold an optimistic view of SNS platforms. Shirky (2008), for example, refers to them as places of collaboration generating social change, and claims that "easier and wider dissemination of information changes group awareness" (p. 151). This may be so in theory though the harsh reality of everyday life often stands in stark contrast with any imaginary advantages, leading to further inequality rather than increased global homogeneity. The positive effects of public Facebook pages on individuals with ICCs remain unclear, as does their effectiveness in meeting their needs. Psycho-social benefits still seem to be the main motivators behind the interactants' behaviour on SNS platforms, despite Merchant's (2020) claims that, these days, individuals "seek greater agency in managing, tracking, and having ownership of their health" (p. 411).

The experiential representations of living with endometriosis that arise from the FPOSD uttered by the Facebook pages also inform their followers' judgement and reasoning. As Weinstein (1980) points out, if what happened to a page follower is considered controllable, followers may create a stereotypical image of that individual and assume that they were at risk "because he or she failed to take any action to control the risk (p. 814)." Nevertheless, the pages and their followers also employ AD, mainly through the use of relational attributive processes, to express empathy and understanding ('I am so sorry to hear this').

7. Conclusion

The FPOSD on both Facebook pages is mainly characterised by intrinsically symbolic relational processes depicting individuals with endometriosis as in control of their own bodies, and continuously defining entities related to the condition. Both are discursive acts of power that encourage the ideology of positive thinking. FPOSD is also employed by the pages to dictate which actions followers should take. It may exert inadvertent effects on users due to its unreasonableness, especially when uttered from a position of power. As such, it could be seen as a type of neoliberal empowerment discourse that maintains systems of truth which regulate users' everyday practice of living with an ICC. FPOSD may come across as paternalistic, whereas AD merely describes entities, evoking sympathy. The study's lack of multimodal analysis may be seen as a possible limitation. Evaluating the negative or positive influence of SNS usage on individuals through linguistic analysis remains a considerable challenge, which ideally requires the complementary use of surveys or interviews. An increased use of AD on Facebook pages targeting individuals with ICCs and amongst their followers is recommended.

Declaration of Competing Interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

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